

Qroo Spanish Crew

Conjugating Verbs in the Imperfect Tense

Introduction

The imperfect tense in Spanish is used to describe actions that were ongoing, habitual, or incomplete in the past. It is also used for setting the scene or providing background information in narratives. This guide will explain how to conjugate regular verbs in the imperfect tense and then cover irregular verbs, which are few in this tense.

Regular Verbs

Regular verbs in the imperfect tense follow predictable patterns based on their infinitive endings: **-AR**, **-ER**, and **-IR**. The conjugations are uniform, making this one of the easiest tenses to learn.

Conjugation Endings for Regular Verbs

Subject Pronoun -AR Ending -ER Ending -IR Ending

yo	-aba	-ía	-ía
tú	-abas	-ías	-ías
él/ella/usted	-aba	-ía	-ía
nosotros/nosotras	-ábamos	-íamos	-íamos
vosotros/vosotras (Spain only)	-abais	-íais	-íais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	-aban	-ían	-ían

Examples of Regular Verbs

-AR Verbs

- **Hablar (to speak):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	hablaba
tú	hablabas
él/ella/usted	hablaba
nosotros	hablábamos
vosotros	hablabais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	hablaban

-ER Verbs

- **Comer (to eat):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	comía
tú	comías
él/ella/usted	comía
nosotros	comíamos
vosotros	comíais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	comían

-IR Verbs

- **Vivir (to live):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	vivía
tú	vivías
él/ella/usted	vivía
nosotros	vivíamos
vosotros	vivíais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	vivían

Irregular Verbs

The imperfect tense is unique because it has only three irregular verbs. These verbs must be memorized as they do not follow the regular patterns.

Irregular Verbs

- **Ser (to be):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	era
tú	eras
él/ella/usted	era
nosotros	éramos
vosotros	erais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	eran

Ir (to go):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	iba
tú	ibas
él/ella/usted	iba
nosotros	íbamos
vosotros	ibais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	iban

Ver (to see):

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	veía
tú	veías
él/ella/usted	veía
nosotros	veíamos
vosotros	veíais
ellos/ellas/ustedes	veían

Usage of the Imperfect Tense

The imperfect tense is commonly used in the following situations:

1. Habitual or Repeated Actions:

- Example: Cuando era niño, jugaba en el parque. (When I was a child, I used to play in the park.)

2. Ongoing Actions in the Past:

- Example: Estaba leyendo un libro cuando me llamaste. (I was reading a book when you called me.)

3. Descriptions in the Past:

- Example: La casa era grande y tenía un jardín bonito. (The house was big and had a beautiful garden.)

4. Telling Time or Age:

- Example: Eran las cinco de la tarde. (It was five in the afternoon.)
- Example: Tenía diez años. (I was ten years old.)

Summary

The imperfect tense is a straightforward tense with regular conjugations and only three irregular verbs: **ser**, **ir**, and **ver**. It is essential for describing past habitual actions, ongoing events, and background details. With consistent practice, mastering the imperfect tense will greatly enhance your ability to narrate past events in Spanish.